

STORIES PAST AND PRESENT

Class - VIII



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STORIES PAST AND PRESENT

Class - VIII

(Experimental Edition)

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PREFACE

The Govt. of Odisha has decided to strengthen the teaching/learning of English in Odia medium Govt. Schools. The English Language Teaching Institute (ELTI) has already prepared a handbook on teaching English at the primary level. About sixty thousand teachers have been trained with the help of the book during 2016-2017 and each teacher has been provided with a copy of the book. Next, the ELTI with the help of SCERT and OPEPA has prepared this new series of textbooks in English from Class-III to Class-VIII based on sound principles of English Language Teaching and principles of pedagogy enshrined in NCF 2005. The books have been tried out with real learners and teachers. Necessary corrections have been made accordingly. I wish the teachers to read the introduction and notes for them provided in the books and teach the books accordingly. I also want the inspecting officials to go through the textbooks and supervise classes accordingly. The workbooks are carefully built into the textbooks. The teachers should use the books following a learner-centred approach and make learners do the tasks. They should correct learners' scripts and provide feedback. The Inspecting Officials are expected to supervise this regularly. Each textbook has also in-built tests to test the performance of both the learners and the teachers. Language indicators for each class are also provided at the end of the book for the guidance of both the teachers and the Inspecting Officials. This will help the parents to check the progress of their wards. Attempts are also being made to prepare similar text books in other subjects from the coming years based on these sound principles. But unfortunately, our attempts to strengthen teaching/learning through good textbooks failed to yield expected results due to widespread prevalence of cheap bazaar notes (Meaning Books) prepared only with the motives of commercial gains. These books provide cheap ready-made helps by working out the tasks/activities thereby preventing students from getting/developing skills and restrict them from the pleasure of doing the workbook tasks/activities on their own.

I am sure, the new series will help our learners excel in all the four language skills of English --- Listening, Speaking, Reading and Writing. I thank the Editors and the Reviewers for their sincere efforts in preparing the excellent materials. I also thank Dr. Manmatha Kundu, the Academic Adviser and Mr. Indramani Tripathy, the Director of ELTI under whose academic and administrative guidance the books are prepared.

Any suggestions for the improvement of the book are welcome.

Commissioner-cum-Secretary
Department of School and Mass Education,
Govt. of Odisha

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INTRODUCTION

This introduction is an extension of the introduction to the detailed textbook for class VIII.

Of all the four language skills- listening, speaking, reading and writing- reading is the most important, especially, for learning English in our context. It has already been stated that language is primarily learnt through exposure, and the exposure mainly comes through listening and reading. In our context, while the scope for listening to English is limited, there is wide scope for reading in English because of availability of a wide range of materials – newspapers, journals, books etc. And, those who have gained mastery over English language in India have mostly done through reading in English. It has also been stated before that language is learnt in meaningful contexts. But in our day to day contexts, there is a little English which is not enough to learn English. But in reading materials, especially in literature, the writers build contexts in their writing. The characters in a novel or in a short story, for example, interact in a context and the reader while reading literature in English learns English in context.

In view of these facts, the role of supplementary readers is very important. Usually, supplementary readers in English include mainly stories, novels and plays. In order to read and enjoy stories and novels in English, one should have fast reading skills in English. The main purpose of supplementary readers is to develop fast reading skills in our learners. We call these supplementary readers as 'Non-detailed Textbooks' in contrast to 'Detailed Textbooks' which intend to develop the close reading skills of our learners.

Detailed Textbooks used for developing learners' close reading skills lay the foundation for fast reading skills, which is why, the detailed textbooks include language activities on vocabulary, grammar and other aspects of language. In contrast, the non-detailed textbooks usually have only reading activities. While detailed textbooks have texts of prose and poems, non-

detailed texts have mainly short stories which are easier to read and comprehend. Non-detailed textbooks are usually introduced at a higher level, in our case, at the level of class VIII. The assumption behind this late introduction of Non-detailed Textbook is that the long use of detailed textbooks has prepared the ground for fast reading skills. But unfortunately in our context, the learners are found not to have developed the basic language skills to read fast the Non-detailed Textbooks. As a result, the Non-detailed Textbooks do not serve the expected purpose. The learners hardly ever read the texts on their own for developing fast reading skills.

To set right this situation we have prepared this Non-detailed Textbook for class VIII in a different way. We have provided some language activities which are comparatively simpler and less in number than the language activities in the Detailed Textbook. These simple language activities can equip the learners with required English-language skills to read fast. The Sense Group Paragraphs (SGPs) are comparatively longer and learners are asked to read in less time. The stories in the book are simple and interesting. For developing faster reading skills, we have provided tail-pieces to all the lessons. The themes of the tail pieces are similar to that of the main lessons and are short and simple. Thus, while the main texts develop the English language skills of the learners, the tail pieces develop fast reading skills. This Non-detailed Textbook is, therefore, a mixture of detailed and non-detailed textbook. And, like the Detailed Textbook, this Non-detailed Textbook has also two step-lessons, which will serve as steps to reach the main texts.

The detailed textbooks as stated before are for developing learners' close reading skills-read slowly going back and forth and when necessary reading between the lines. Non-detailed textbooks are to develop fast reading skills. But a good reader should be flexible in his/her reading speed depending on the material he reads. If a part of a text is easy, the reader reads fast till comes a difficult part where she/he will have to slow his/her speed-reading slowly between the lines. A good reader is like a good driver who is flexible in his/her speed depending on the road condition and the traffic. Similarly, a good reader increases or decreases his/her speed depending on the material s/he reads - easy or difficult.

Notes to Students

You must have read what we wrote for you in the introduction to your detailed textbook. This book is slightly different from that book. Here, you have to read only stories. The stories are simple and interesting. The activities are also simple. You can do most of them on your own with minimum help from your teacher.

Remember one thing- it is not necessary to understand the meaning of all the words to understand a paragraph, and you can guess the meaning of a difficult word from the context. It is not always necessary to ask your teacher the meaning or look up a word in a dictionary. Let us see an example. What is the meaning of 'thrifty'? You don't know because the word is not used in a context. Let's use the word in a context- "Cows love to eat grass, straw and thrifty". Can you guess the meaning of 'thrifty' now? Yes, it is like grass and straw – a cow food. How could you guess the meaning of the word? This is because the word is used in a context. The words, 'cow' and its food 'grass' and 'straw' in the context of cow eating them help us understand the meaning of the word 'thrifty'. For your information, the word 'thrifty' is a nonsensical word. Still you are able to guess its meaning when used in a context. So you can guess the meanings of difficult words from contexts. Therefore, read the stories without bothering about difficult words.

The tail-pieces at the end of main lessons are for you to read on your own. Keep on reading. You'll be able to understand them. Questions are likely to be set from these pieces as unseen passages in the exam. If you read them, it will be easy on your part to answer the questions.

Notes to Teachers

You must have read the introduction to the detailed textbook and the tips for you on some techniques of teaching.

You must read yourself what we have written for your students and help them comprehend the introduction for them. Earlier, the non-detailed text-book was taken very lightly by both the teachers and the learners. But this time, you have to take this very seriously and make your learners do all

the tasks meant for them. Also, see that your learners read the tail-pieces as questions may be set from these passages as unknown texts. You should ask them to read 'Tail-pieces' in the class on their own and ask some comprehension questions. In order to do that you have to read these tail-pieces beforehand and prepare some comprehension questions.

Abbreviations used in the book :

SGP	:	Sense Group Paragraph
BS	:	Brain Storming
MT	:	Mental Talk
VMDT	:	Visual Memory Development Technique
MCQ	:	Multiple Choice Question